

Overall, the results get slightly skewed in favour of FineReader because of its fine performance in the fax test. If we exclude the fax test, and just concentrate on the laser, photocopy and dot matrix documents, Recognita Plus comes out marginally better than FineReader and even Presto! OCR is on par with FineReader. So, if you work in an area where you regularly have to OCR photocopied documents (say from books and reports) and not worry that much about reproducing the exact formatting, Recognita Plus might be a slightly better option. However, we feel you should stick to **FineReader**, which comes out tops with a recognition accuracy of 95 per cent across all documents, followed by TextBridge with 93 per cent accuracy. If you are a media company and receive faxed press releases on a regular basis or a sales company with branch offices sending fax reports, then FineReader would be quite a valuable tool.

Right in formation

If you constantly receive reports and other data from outstation sources, tables will form an inevitable part of these documents. It becomes essential, therefore, that

Recognising the Source

Many of the OCR software under test allowed us to specify the source material in terms of whether it was a dot matrix or typewriter output, whether it had tables or multiple columns in it. We did try testing the OCR by using these settings instead of the default settings and without exception we found that the accuracy dipped, especially with the dot matrix option. For instance, CuneiForm had 30 errors without the dot matrix option, but this increased to 49. The same was the case with OmniPage, Presto! OCR, and PageGenei Pro. FineReader's 1 error in the typing test increased to 2 with the

typewriter source selected. TextBridge Pro lost most of its recognition in the Fax test when we specified the paper source as degraded.

So, we suggest that you stick to the automatic or default settings before scanning. Also, the developers recommend scanning in gray scale (as opposed to line art) for better accuracy as the contrast levels are better adjusted. However, this again doesn't make much of a difference with the laser print document. It's only the fax document in FineReader that showed an improvement in accuracy levels with gray scale scanning.

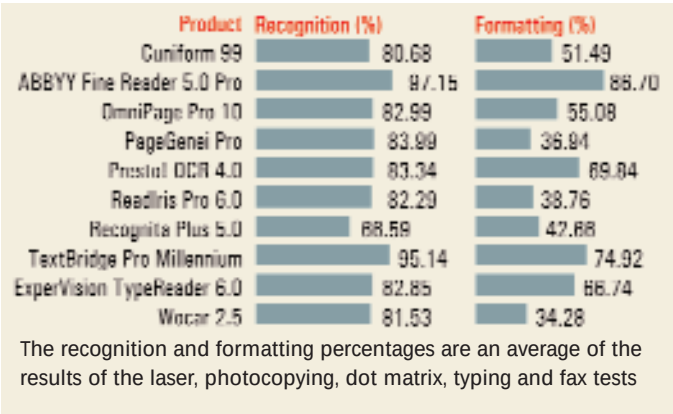
an OCR retains the cell structure of the tables even while maintaining accuracy. Two software that really stood out in this respect were Presto! OCR and TypeReader. Both of them were 100 per cent accurate in recognising the table structure, even recognising the split cells as different cells. Presto! OCR was even better, for it had a marginally higher word accuracy than

Expersvision. We found that most OCR recognised the first table (with just rows and columns) without any problems. But the second table with wrapped text and split cells was a problem, and the software tended to recognise each line (even with wrapped text) as

an individual cell, and interchanged text around with the split cells.

TextBridge claimed it doesn't recognise forms and therefore didn't do well, but **OmniPage Pro**, the counterpart from the same company did the best when it came to recognising the form. However, we are sceptical about the actual usability of doing an OCR on forms, for even if the structure of the form is retained, lines in which you fill-up data aren't recognised, so there will still be some formatting work to be done before you start off with the form.

Even with the newspapers and the magazines, OmniPage Pro came out best in terms of retaining format as well as accuracy and it had no problem recognising text on a background. OmniPage worked by retaining the different columns in the multi-column stories as frames. However, there were some problems in changing the scanner settings in OmniPage as the application crashed. Also, while performing the OCR for the newspapers with automatic



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